Breeding humans?

The biggest danger with organ and tissue transplants is **rejection**. A patient's body will see a new organ as an invader and try to get rid of it. Transplant recipients must take anti-rejection drugs to stop this from happening. The drugs are called **immunosuppressants**, because their job is to suppress the **immune system**. Rejection is less likely to occur if the organ comes from a close relative. Identical twins are the best match, and a brother or sister may be the next best.

Imagine you could grow a copy of yourself – then you would have the perfect match if you ever needed a transplant! But would that be fair on the other 'you', who only existed to donate organs? Acts like that could be illegal.

Apart from laws, doctors also have rules about treatment called **medical ethics**. Government health departments and hospitals have ethics committees. The committees make rules that say which medical actions are right and wrong.

☞ **1** Decide whether you think each of these examples is right, wrong or illegal. Write 'R' for right, 'W' for wrong and 'I' for illegal.

- Grow a person's cells and then inject them back into the same person. _____
- Accept a donation of a kidney from a brother or sister. _____
- Accept a culture of bone marrow cells that come from another person. _____
- Accept a heart from a person killed in an accident. _____
- A heavy smoker receives a lung transplant from a dead accident victim. _____
- Have a second child so they can donate a kidney to an existing child. _____
- Purchase a kidney from a poor person in a developing country. _____
- Buy a transplant heart from a secret supplier in another country. _____

2 Choose one of the above examples and write a paragraph in your workbook explaining your opinion about whether it is right, wrong or illegal.

3 Who do you think should make final decisions in cases like these?

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